

The Historical Development of Philosophy (1869)

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The Historical Development of Philosophy 1

*H. Brøchner: Bidrag til Opfattelsen af Filosofiens
historiske Udvikling*

[115]

[Contributions to the Understanding of the Historical Development of Philosophy]
(1869)

One generally reads with a certain astonishment that the most significant men of the past have most often been precisely those to whom their contemporaries paid the least heed; one is surprised to learn which men were preferred to them, what current of the age they had against them, how solitary their position was; and one feels assured that in our day such things are over, that our age knows how to find merit in its most hidden corner, seize it and draw it forth into the light; one flatters oneself with the thought that the names which sound most often and most loudly in our day will also be the ones on the lips of posterity. Not many things in the world are as certain as that in this one is sadly mistaken. Names that are now celebrated, persons whom everybody now knows, will be a nothing to posterity, and personalities who are now known and valued by a small circle will leave behind them lasting traces of their life and work. But worse off, after all, is he who outlives his fame than he whose fame grows so slowly that only when the age has caught up with the personality does it stand out in clear outline.

Professor *Brøchner* is a man who belongs to the latter class; he is no popular man; he has never taken a single step toward popularity, and he is far too far ahead of his surroundings to be valued by them; for one values only what one understands. He has [116] worked in silence, and had he been carried off by illness before he at last, last year, began the publication of his writings, scarcely half a score of people would have known that the country had lost its most thorough and most incisive thinker. Fortunately he has come through his long illness, and the publication of his works, awaited with such great longing by his few disciples, has been begun.

When one considers the book whose title is given above, one's first impression is a painful feeling. Is it not sad that Denmark has gradually been reduced to such smallness that the best writings can find no readers, can reap no recognition, can yield no return and can receive no criticism? Would it not be better, both for the man of science himself and for the whole of European cultivation, if men like Professor Brøchner and our other significant men of science lived in one of the great principal countries, were developed through criticism and received stimulus from every side? Perhaps it would be better.

But it seems to me that the lot of such a man has its beauty even under the present circumstances. He and his like are the farthest advanced vedettes or outposts of the great European culture in the high North; their position is the most exposed; for outpost duty is severe and dangerous; but precisely thereby their scientific life demands a firmness of character, a courage, at certain times a soldier's daring, which less uncommon conditions do not develop, and which inspires love for the man, adorns and strengthens his talent.

Professor Brøchner's work as a teacher at the University, though it has lasted several years, is not yet of such long standing that its influence can be clearly traced; but that it is significant is certain, and anyone who knows many of the younger students will be able to bear witness to it. Professor Brøchner is the first philosopher freed from all theology that our University has possessed; if G. Sibbern, who has had to pay dearly for his liberal-mindedness, is excepted, he is also the only living Danish one. He was appointed at a time when theological influences of the most varied kinds were powerful here at home; he has spoken from his solitary lectern to his not always numerous audience, while all around him the spiritually reactionary voices that drowned out everything else shouted to one another and confused every thinking brain. He has held fast to the [117] conviction which from his early youth showed itself to him in the clarity of truth; in the strongest anti-rational storms he has held the banner of reason fast.

How many of the University's other professors, e.g. of the Faculty of Natural Science, have not shared his way of seeing, and yet, as is the common custom among learned people, have kept quiet in order to avoid opposition and unpleasantness, and have always maintained that there was no reason to speak "so long as no one did anything to them, made no encroachment on their freedom." As if a man were a man of science if the truth did not burn him like a live coal on the tongue; as if he who kept silent did not leave in the lurch the individual who speaks, and did not contribute his share to producing the false appearance that the latter, with his way of seeing, stands literally alone, that his view of life is a kind of whim, an unreasonable oddity, sprung up in a brain twisted by false metaphysics, etc. As I said, Professor Brøchner has found no support. But this much is certain: if there is anyone among the younger men who study the sciences of the spirit who in the course of his university career has received a strong impression of the unconditional right of free inquiry, of the validity of humanity over against all dogmas, then he surely owes this impression to Professor Brøchner; and the reviewer can at least testify for himself that scarcely anything, amid the bewildering battle of crisscrossing opinions and systems, has been such a support to him and such a direction to seek the truth by the way of reason as Professor Brøchner's strictly scientific inquiry

and manfully unbending stance.

The treatise on *Filosofiens historiske Udvikling* is surely the most significant of the writings the author has so far published. It is a work that will keep its place in our literature. It will be an excellent guide for anyone who takes up the study of the history of philosophy, and it is so new and original, so well thought through, so tested again and again, that even in the rich German literature it would attract great notice — what a role, then, does its publication not play in a philosophical literature as poor as the Danish!

Professor Brøchner has not wished to give the history of philosophy in and for itself. He has set himself a larger goal: he has wished to give the philosophy of this history. What does that mean? When does history get its philosophy? It gets it when it is satisfactorily shown that it is not a sequence of accidental, disconnected, lawless [118] events, when, rather, it is seen to be governed by law. That it must be subject to a lawfulness Brøchner establishes by pointing to the essence of its originator, the human race, whose unfolding cannot be accidental or planless but must be a real development. In this word *development*, the concept that is the center of the whole of recent German and English philosophy, there lie rolled up all the determinations or laws that a thinking consideration of history is able to unfold. If history has a coherence, then no historical state of affairs, of any kind that can be named, can be without lateral influence in all directions; if history has a development, then no historical fact, no matter of what kind, can be without after-effect out into the future. If one takes a single small domain out of history, literary history for example, it stands in connection with all the other branches; if one takes out of that in turn a single section such as the history of philosophy, one once again artificially isolates a single part of history, which forms a whole of its own only relatively. But the development that takes place in the great life of culture is found also in this particular organ of it, just as, conversely, the lawfulness we find here is a guarantee to us that arbitrariness cannot reign at any point.

The individuals of whom the race consists no doubt believe that they think as their own individual reason prompts them, as they can and as they will. In reality, however, they think also, and first and foremost, as they *must*. They are derived beings; they have their thoughts from themselves as little as their life; just as the universal, just as the race *lives* in them, so too the human race *thinks* in the individuals. The ideas it is preparing appear, first, in an embryonic state in individual thinkers, but without these being conscious of it themselves, a good while before those ideas, fully developed, take their place in science. Second, the race's stage of development at the given point in time stands at the same time like a fate over the individuals. Although the very ideas whose

organs the individuals are urge them in many ways to draw further consequences from those thoughts, to pursue them out in new, future directions, the spirit of the age is nevertheless a power that encompasses all the individual's endeavors, holds him back without his being conscious of it, and prevents him from pursuing a thought beyond the horizon of his age.

[119] Yet the fate that governs the individual's thinking is more composite still: not only is he unable to overstep the bounds of the contemporary stage of the race, but so long as this stage has not yet fully ripened and come to rest in equilibrium about its own center, the preceding, abandoned stage still constantly works as a power that hampers the individual's striving. This too is a law, grounded in the concept of development as well as confirmed by historical experience. If, finally, one notices that often within one and the same historical age diametrically opposed tendencies assert themselves, then the philosopher of history is able even here to show us how the standpoint of development on which the whole age stands is, without the two opposed camps being conscious of it, common to them both, and unites those who regard themselves as opponents in principle under the all-governing form of development, which, marking friend and foe alike with its stamp, shapes itself into two opposed schools as into two hemispheres that complete each other.

It is laws of this nature that Professor Brøchner has demonstrated in the history of philosophy, and in order to confirm the results of his inquiry still further he has, as is his habit, followed the procedure of furnishing both proof and counterproof. He does not content himself with illustrating his line of thought by examples; but once this is done he chooses such cases as apparently constitute exceptions to the law, and shows how it finds its confirmation in them as well.

Yet the excellence of his new book is not to be sought solely in the demonstration of laws, nor in the study of the relation between the conscious and the unconscious in human nature, a domain which, incidentally, may very nearly be called Professor Brøchner's special domain; it rests besides on the exhaustive knowledge of the history of philosophy by which the author takes so high a rank among the thinking minds of Europe. It is this that has made it possible for him to furnish such masterly investigations as those of Aristotle and Kant, who are here understood in a depth and with a clarity found scarcely anywhere else. So clear a line of thought begets a clear and beautiful exposition, and there are therefore large parts of this work where the author has succeeded, despite the refractory nature of the subject, in bending it into harmonious forms, and, despite
[120] the refractory nature of his pen, now and then in letting the mood lend the presentation

a gentle, spiritualized color. So it is, for example, in the portrayal of Neoplatonism and of Giordano Bruno.

This is not the place to discuss the details of the book, even if the reviewer were equal to the task, which he is not. I shall, on the other hand, raise some objections to the plan of the book and to the author's standpoint.

The plan is not altogether even, and the author's way of seeing is not the same toward all subjects. He has, of course, the right to present the longitudinal coherence of philosophy by itself and to see it as a relative whole. But it is also clear that such a conception must of necessity become very abstract and rather one-sided. What seems to me somewhat unsteady is this, that the author sometimes takes the lateral coherence into account and sometimes does not. In my view no philosophy can be fully understood unless it is seen in its close connection with all the other branches of the literature of its time, with the contemporary historical events and with the national spirit of its people. When the subject is Greek philosophy, the author is willing to see it in its connection with the whole Greek spirit and culture, and to hold that only in this way can it be understood. But when the subject is modern French, German, English philosophy, it is treated as though it led a secluded existence without relation to the national spirit, without relation to the country's poetry, history, etc. Is it not strange not to introduce the presentation of German philosophy at all with a sketch of the gifts and limits of the German spirit, but to regard it without further ado as all-embracing? It perhaps seems so to Brøchner because he stands so near it; but is sheer narrow-mindedness, then, to blame for its never having caught on in England? I doubt it in the very highest degree. I for my part hold not only that at bottom it is unintelligible without a preliminary study of the German national character through its poetry, its criticism, its literature as a whole, but also that several distinctive traits in its individual heroes, as for example the strong assertion of the I, the strong enthusiasm for freedom in Fichte, are first seen in their true light when one shows Napoleon's despotism over Germany in the background.

I admire Brøchner's gift for presenting the main points and the main features of a system; but in all philosophers is the systematic element what is most essential and most important? Is the skeleton everything, the body nothing? Ought one not at least to be wary of stamping interesting, heterogeneous philosophical phenomena with the same official school-label when quite different national spirits have found expression in them? Condillac is usually presented as an appendix to Locke; is there not all the same a yawning gulf between their whole manner of philosophizing? Is there not, on the score of nationality, a still stronger intellectual kinship between Descartes and Condillac than [121]

there is, with respect to the results of thought, between Condillac and Locke? Does the key to Descartes's philosophy not lie in the spirit of the whole great French century, and is it not connected with the theology, the poetry, the legislation and the landscape gardening of the time? In a word, do not the spirit of the stock and the national spirit also belong to the fate that is mightier than the fate of individuals, and that works on them unconsciously and hampers them? It seems to me that this new fate deserved a stronger emphasis.

And since we are speaking of fate, has not Brøchner himself his own? He belongs to the large group of philosophers who since Hegel's time have tried, while retaining everything the great master won, to make good his mistakes, avoid his overreachings, and immerse themselves in the reality of which he, with his contempt for nature, often disdained empirical knowledge. Such points as the inquiry into laws and the demonstration of the relation between the conscious and the unconscious show how fully Brøchner stands at the height of his age and shares in its endeavors. Nevertheless, with all this he still stands, after all, on Hegel's ground, and I will not deny that I am inclined to believe that a conscious-unconscious after-effect of the panlogism he has abandoned sometimes holds him back and sometimes misleads him into a priori constructions that scarcely hold water. Among these I count his division of philosophy into three main epochs, of which two are past, while the third, the philosophy of the future, is now about to begin. The task that he sets this philosophy of the future the thinkers of the preceding epoch have already striven to accomplish, and whether the thinkers who arise in the centuries immediately following will be more fortunate than those of the present one in avoiding [122] a one-sided emphasis on nature or on spirit is a question. Whether they will in the end make use of the method of inquiry that Brøchner prescribes for them is a still greater one.

The dialectical method, which has so far been practiced only in a single country and over a short span of time, has not stood the test in its original form. It has been abandoned even in Germany, and it is not used in any other country. That the dialectical is a power in the human spirit and in the universe I am far from doubting; but with what adaptation the method can be used Brøchner has not shown. All of us who work would like nothing better than an excellent tool; but since the highly ingenious one that has so far been put into our hands cannot be used, no one can hold it against us that for the present we prefer to make use of the coarser implements of the special sciences, which at least do not break in the hand.

Finally, I see a remnant of Hegel's influence in the way in which Brøchner disposes of

Oriental philosophy and defines the Greek. The Oriental he does not reckon with — a little prematurely, it seems to me. There exist extremely complex, extraordinarily interesting Indian systems which have not yet been translated at all; they are, if the reviewer may take others at their word, philosophical in their essence; they have no special relation to religion, and they must surely be examined before they can be sacrificed to the form of philosophy which, as representing “the immediate unity of nature and spirit,” must necessarily be the first.

Brøchner arrives at this last determination by beginning with stamping the Greeks as *the people of beauty*. This too seems to me an undoubted after-effect of Hegelianism. Such propositions are all too true, that is to say, all too abstract to be true. The Greeks are no more the people of beauty than the Jews are the people of religion, or *Don Juan* the perfect opera, etc. The Greeks express a single, definite, historical ideal of beauty, and they came by a purely historical route to express it. This ideal is only in certain respects the highest that has arisen up to now, and it became so for purely historical reasons. The Greeks are the inventors and founders of cities that are at the same time states. The perilous situation of these cities among only half-subjugated tribes, and their life of feuding among themselves, made necessary the gymnastic education, which in turn brought it about that the perfect gymnast was valued and admired to an unheard-of degree, was crowned with wreaths at public festivals, won the right to a statue, and [123] became the ideal of beauty. Is not, then, the determination that the Greeks are the people of the city-state more deep-lying and less unconditional than the determination that they are the people of beauty? It seems to me that it is, and it seems to me reasonable that from the Greeks' wholly peculiar political life one would be able to arrive at many of the determinations that are the most decisive for their philosophy.

It is possible that I am wrong in some of these objections. If, however, they are not unfounded, the defects which they presumably hit nonetheless in no way rule out the great excellence of the book. At bottom they only establish the validity of one of the author's own laws, namely this: that the older epoch, so long as the new one has not yet emerged in its full development, works, unconsciously for the individual thinker, to a certain degree as a hindrance on his conscious striving to bring forth the philosophy of the new age.
